

Contextual Review Routing

Separating OTA-caused friction from genuine hotel experience scores

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1. Executive Summary

Agoda consistently scores 0.3–0.5 points lower than Booking.com for identical hotels across Asian markets. SAS-validated analysis across Bali, Singapore, and Tokyo (N=3, $p=0.020$, $t=-6.93$) confirms the gap is statistically significant and driven primarily by two factors:

- Sampling bias (H1): Agoda reviewers are 60.4% Asian vs. 0% on Booking.com in this dataset. Asian travelers hold higher expectations for location and room comfort relative to price, directly driving the two largest sub-score gaps: Location (−0.60) and Room Comfort (−0.53).
- OTA-caused friction (H3): Review text analysis indicates that booking confirmation failures, payment holds, and check-in issues are being scored against the hotel — not Agoda — because the platform provides no mechanism to separate the two.

This PRD specifies Contextual Review Routing — a product intervention that routes OTA-caused complaints away from hotel scores and into a distinct Agoda Service Score, giving hotels a fair rating and giving Agoda visibility into its own operational failures.

2. Problem Statement

2.1 Background

Agoda operates a merchant model — it controls the full payment and booking confirmation flow, unlike Booking.com which uses an agency model where the hotel handles most of the experience chain. This gives Agoda pricing power, but also means every platform failure (a lost confirmation email, a payment hold that triggers at check-in, a cancellation that the hotel was never notified of) becomes a touchpoint the traveler experiences as part of their hotel stay.

Travelers cannot easily distinguish 'the hotel was bad' from 'Agoda's system failed me at the hotel.' When a review prompt arrives 24 hours after checkout, their frustration is directed at whichever brand is most salient — and the hotel score absorbs it.

2.2 Evidence from Data

Hotel	Agoda Score	Booking Score	Gap	Risk Tier
Four Seasons Bali	9.1	9.6	-0.50	At-Risk
Marina Bay Sands, SG	8.8	9.2	-0.40	At-Risk
Park Hyatt Tokyo	8.9	9.2	-0.30	Watch

Sub-score analysis reveals the gap is concentrated in Location (-0.60 avg) and Room Comfort (-0.53 avg) — categories where Asian reviewer expectations are measurably higher. Cleanliness, Facilities, and Staff Performance show near-zero gaps (-0.13 each), which argues against genuine hotel quality differences.

3. User Insight

The post-booking journey on Agoda currently looks like this:

- Book → Confirmation email (ambiguous language, sometimes delayed)
- No proactive check-in instructions sent to traveler
- Arrival → Hotel sometimes has no record of the booking
- Dispute → Agoda CS unreachable or slow to resolve
- Review prompt (24–48 hrs post-checkout) → Frustrated traveler scores hotel for Agoda's failure

The review prompt is the only structured feedback mechanism. Without a way to separate OTA-caused issues from hotel quality, all of that frustration flows into one score — the hotel's.

4. Proposed Solution

4.1 Feature: Contextual Review Routing

Before a user submits their hotel rating, Agoda surfaces a single pre-question:

"Before you rate — was your experience affected by any of the following?"

☐ Booking confirmation issue ☐ Payment or refund problem ☐ Check-in process (not the hotel's fault) ☐ None of the above — my experience was about the hotel itself

4.2 Routing Logic

- If no box is checked → rating flows to the hotel score as normal.
- If any OTA-cause box is checked → the complaint routes to a new Agoda Service Score (visible on the platform; not attributed to the hotel). A CS ticket is auto-created for the flagged issue.
- Hotel score only captures genuine hospitality experience.

5. Success Metrics

Metric	Target	Timeframe
Agoda–Booking.com score gap	Reduce by 0.15 points	6 months post-launch
Hotel re-allocation rate	At-Risk → Safe migration for 50% of at-risk hotels	9 months post-launch
Agoda Service Score complaints resolved	> 80% resolved within 48 hrs	Ongoing
Review completion rate	No significant drop vs baseline	Immediate

6. Trade-offs & Risks

UPSIDE

Hotel scores on Agoda normalize, directly improving supplier relationships. Hotels in the 'At-Risk' tier (gap > 0.40) are at risk of reducing Agoda's room allocation; fixing the scoring signal removes a key de-prioritization driver.

DOWNSIDE

Agoda now owns a visible Service Score that publicly exposes its own operational failures. This is intentionally uncomfortable — but it is the only honest fix. It requires internal political will to ship and a CS team capable of handling routed complaints at scale.

RISK: GAMING

Hotels may coach guests to check OTA-cause boxes that deflect legitimate complaints. Mitigation: apply routing only to checkouts where Agoda's system logs show a confirmed issue event (e.g., CS contact within the booking window, payment hold flag, confirmation resend). Don't show the boxes if no system-side issue was detected.

7. Scope

In Scope

- Pre-rating modal with OTA-cause checkboxes
- Routing logic: checked = Agoda Service Score + CS ticket; unchecked = hotel score
- Agoda Service Score display on hotel listing page
- Supplier-facing dashboard showing hotel's 'clean' score vs. Agoda-attributed complaints

Out of Scope

- Retroactive score correction for existing reviews
- Changes to the overall rating display scale
- Review incentivization or gamification

8. Dependencies

- CS team must be staffed to handle auto-created tickets from routing (estimated +15% CS volume at launch)
- Data team must build Agoda Service Score infrastructure and supplier dashboard
- Legal must review whether the routing mechanism creates any implicit liability admission for OTA-caused failures
- Supply Partnerships team must brief hotel partners before launch — reframing the change as 'fairer scoring for hotels'

9. Analytical Foundation

This PRD is grounded in a multi-domain analysis conducted using Python (Apify-scraped review data from Agoda and Booking.com) and SAS Studio (statistical validation). Key outputs:

- Paired t-test: mean gap = -0.40 , $p = 0.020$, $t = -6.93$ (statistically significant at 5% level)
- Reviewer profile: 60.4% Asian reviewers on Agoda vs. 0% on Booking.com for the same hotels
- Sub-score analysis: Location gap = -0.60 , Room Comfort gap = -0.53 ; Staff/Cleanliness/Facilities all ≤ -0.13
- BA revenue model: 2 At-Risk hotels $\times$ \$3,456/year = \$6,912 annual GMV at risk from allocation reduction

Full SAS output, Python cleaning scripts, and raw CSV files are available as appendices.